8,000 cases of land-grabbing complaints. A quarter of them (about 40,000 hectares or one-third of the land grabbed) was to be returned to the original owners, with another quarter mostly between private entities to be settled through judicial process (President's Office 2014a). In addition, the military decided to return to the farmers another 122,000 hectares of land that was grabbed but unused.

In a nutshell, the Hluttaw was non-partisan and persistent on the issue and it was led in this matter by a senior USDP figure. However, there were no consultations between lawmakers and the military representatives that make up twenty-five per cent of seats in the legislature, whose institution was responsible for massive land grabbing. Rather than effectively engaging affected constituencies, the representative function of the concerned lawmakers was limited to questions and motions in the debate. The support of the speaker was important in follow-up and putting pressure on the executive.

Borderland conflicts and peace negotiations

One of the symbols of Myanmar's transition has been the attempt at national reconciliation, in addition to political and economic liberalization. During his inaugural address on 31 March 2011, President U Thein Sein offered an olive branch to ethnic armed groups (EAGs). Afterwards, there were rounds of peace talks: eleven union-level and three state-level ceasefire agreements were signed with fourteen EAGs. In the meantime, a draft nationwide ceasefire agreement was negotiated between the Myanmar government represented by the Union Peacemaking Central Committee (UPCC) and its Working Committee (UPWC), and EAGs represented by the Nationwide Ceasefire Co-ordination Team (NCCT). After seven rounds of negotiation, both sides agreed to a single draft text for a nationwide ceasefire agreement. The next step was to initiate political dialogue. However, there were a number of major and minor setbacks, most notably in Kachin State in 2013 and in Kokang Self Administered Zone in 2015.

The legislature was keen to get involved in the peace process and was persistent in working for the peace process since its inception. But after an initial push, the role of the legislature diminished as the peace process mechanism began to function (see Su Mon Thazin Aung, this volume). There were altogether eight motions and nine questions raised to the Hluttaw, pushing the government to work harder on it. The Speaker Thura U Shwe